

53 Samson

The Nazarite strongman whose great gifts were matched by great weakness, and who died defeating the Philistines.

Samson's birth was announced by the angel of the LORD to a childless woman of Dan. He was to be a Nazarite from the womb, and he would "begin to deliver Israel out of the hand of the Philistines." The Spirit of the LORD gave him astonishing strength: he tore a lion apart, killed a thousand men with a jawbone and carried off a city gate. Yet he was ruled by his appetites. Delilah drew out his secret, and he was blinded and imprisoned. In his death he prayed once more and brought down the house of Dagon.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Shimshon</i> , probably linked to <i>shemesh</i> , "sun"
Family	Son of Manoah of Zorah, of Dan (Judges 13:2)
When	During Philistine rule (Judges 13:1); no firm date
Key places	Zorah, Timnath, Lehi, Gaza, the valley of Sorek
Key people	Manoah and his wife, Delilah, the Philistine lords
Judged	Twenty years (Judges 15:20; 16:31)
Main passages	Judges 13–16
New Testament	Hebrews 11:32

"And Samson called unto the LORD, and said, O Lord GOD, remember me, I pray thee, and strengthen me, I pray thee, only this once, O God, that I may be at once avenged of the Philistines for my two eyes."

Judges 16:28, KJV

The life of Samson

No calendar dates. Many think Samson overlapped with Eli and Samuel, but the text does not say.

Before his birth	● Announced by an angel The angel tells Manoah's barren wife she will bear a Nazarite son. The boy grows, and the Spirit begins to move him. <i>Judges 13:2-25</i>
Young man	● A wife from Timnath He demands a Philistine wife and tears apart a lion. His bride betrays his riddle, and he kills thirty men at Ashkelon to pay the wager. <i>Judges 14:1-20</i>
Wheat harvest	● Foxes and fire With three hundred foxes and firebrands he burns the Philistines' grain. They burn his wife, and he strikes back "hip and thigh." <i>Judges 15:1-8</i>
At Lehi	● The jawbone Judah hands him over bound. The Spirit comes upon him, and he kills a thousand men with a jawbone of an ass. <i>Judges 15:9-20</i>
Later	● Gaza and Delilah He carries off Gaza's gates, then loves Delilah, who is paid to learn his secret. Shaved, he is blinded and set to grind in prison. <i>Judges 16:1-21</i>
His death	● The house of Dagon At a feast to Dagon, Samson prays for strength once more and pulls down the pillars, killing the lords and about three thousand people. <i>Judges 16:22-31</i>

Group notes

Key activities

A Nazarite (Numbers 6:1–21) took no wine or grapes, let no razor touch his head, and kept away from dead bodies. Samson's vow was lifelong and set by God before his birth. Readers differ on how far he broke it before his hair was cut.

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- I Set apart from birth.** He was to be a Nazarite to God from the womb, with no razor on his head. *Judges 13:5*

 - 2 Chose by sight.** He insisted on a Philistine wife because "she pleaseth me well." Judges adds that the LORD was seeking an occasion against the Philistines. *Judges 14:1–4*

 - 3 Tore a lion apart.** The Spirit came mightily upon him, and he rent a young lion with his bare hands, telling no one. *Judges 14:5–6*

 - 4 Took honey from the carcase.** He scooped honey from the lion's body and shared it with his parents without saying where it came from. *Judges 14:8–9*

 - 5 Told a riddle.** "Out of the eater came forth meat, and out of the strong came forth sweetness." *Judges 14:12–18*

 - 6 Paid his debt in blood.** He killed thirty men at Ashkelon and gave their garments to those who had answered the riddle. *Judges 14:19*

 - 7 Burned the harvest.** He used three hundred foxes and firebrands to burn Philistine fields, vineyards and olive groves. *Judges 15:3–5*

 - 8 Let his own people bind him.** He allowed three thousand men of Judah to tie him up and hand him over. *Judges 15:9–13*

 - 9 Struck with a jawbone.** He killed a thousand Philistines at Lehi, then cried to the LORD in his thirst. *Judges 15:14–19*

 - 10 Carried off Gaza's gates.** He lifted the city gate, posts and bar, and carried them to the top of a hill before Hebron. *Judges 16:1–3*

 - 11 Gave away his secret.** Worn down by Delilah, he "told her all his heart," and she had his head shaved. *Judges 16:15–19*

 - 12 Prayed and died.** Blind and captive, he asked God to remember him, then brought down Dagon's house. *Judges 16:28–30*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Samson.

Old Testament

Judges 13-16	The main account
Numbers 6:1-21	The Nazarite law that shaped his life
1 Samuel 12:11	Tradition: some Jewish readers take "Bedan" as Samson
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:11	Hannah vows no razor on her son's head
Echo: Genesis 18:9-14; 25:21	Barren Sarah and Rebekah given sons

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32-34	Among those who "out of weakness were made strong"
Echo: Luke 1:15	John the Baptist, to "drink neither wine nor strong drink"
Echo: Colossians 2:15	Many see Jesus, victorious through his death

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What instructions did the angel give Samson's mother (Judges 13:3-5)?
2. *Understand:* Samson's strength came from the Spirit, not his hair alone (Judges 14:6; 16:20). Why does it matter that "the LORD was departed from him"?
3. *Apply:* Samson often did what was right in his own eyes. Where do your feelings tend to overrule wisdom?
4. *Apply:* God answered Samson's last prayer after his great failure. What would it look like for you to turn back to God this week after a failure?